REQDECK

Your first API requests

A friendly guide to ReqDeck for people who have never sent a request.



What is inside

1 Your first request in five minutes

2 What a request is made of

3 Variables and environments

4 Logging in: authentication

5 Reading the answer

6 History and cURL

7 When something does not work

★ Keys worth knowing

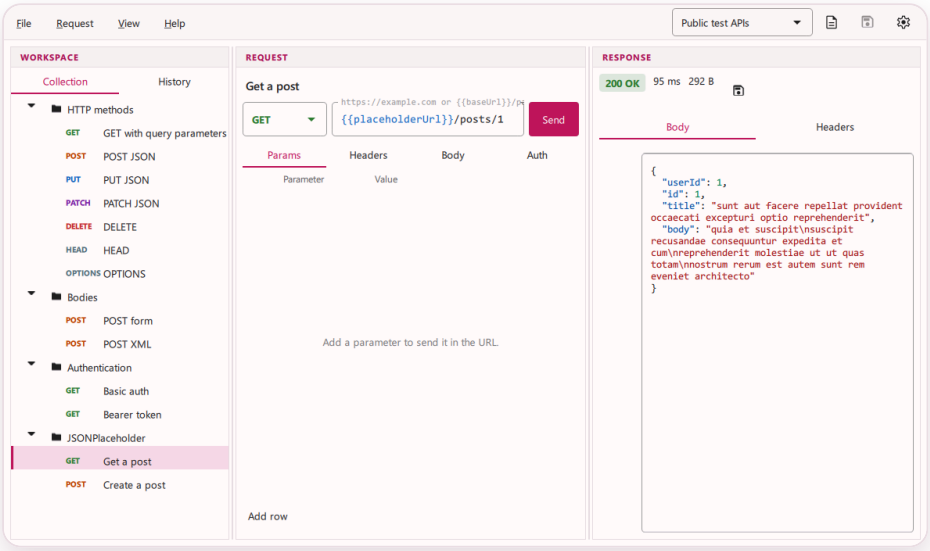
↗ Places to practice

CHAPTER 1

Your first request in five minutes

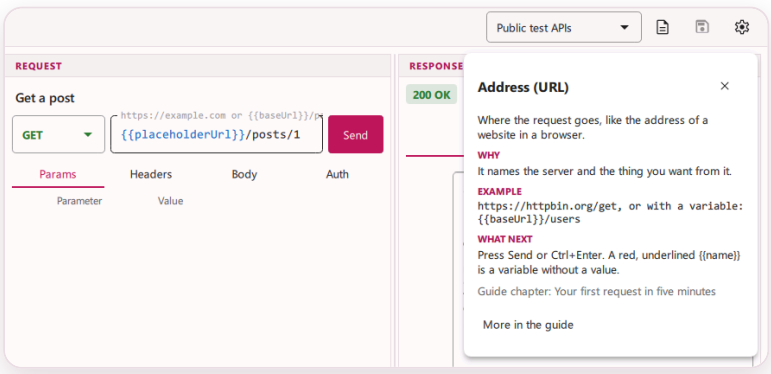
A request is a message your computer sends to a server. The server answers with a response. That is all an API is: a server that answers requests from programs instead of from people with a browser.

1. Start ReqDeck and choose Open Samples.
2. In the Collection on the left, open the folder JSONPlaceholder and click "Get a post".
3. Look at the address in the middle: this is where the request goes.
4. Press Send, or `Ctrl+Enter`.
5. On the right you see the answer: a green 200 OK and the post as JSON.



A request in the middle, its answer on the right.

> **Tip**
>
> Not sure what something is? Point at it and press `F1`.



Press `F1` and ReqDeck explains what is under the pointer.

CHAPTER 2

What a request is made of

Think of a request as a letter. The method is what you ask for, the address is where it goes, parameters and headers are notes on the envelope, and the body is the letter inside.

GET	Read something. No body.
POST	Create something new. Usually with a body.
PUT / **PATCH**	Change something that exists.
DELETE	Remove something.

Parameters are added to the address after a question mark, for example ?page=2. Headers carry information about the request, such as the format you accept. The body carries data, most often as JSON.



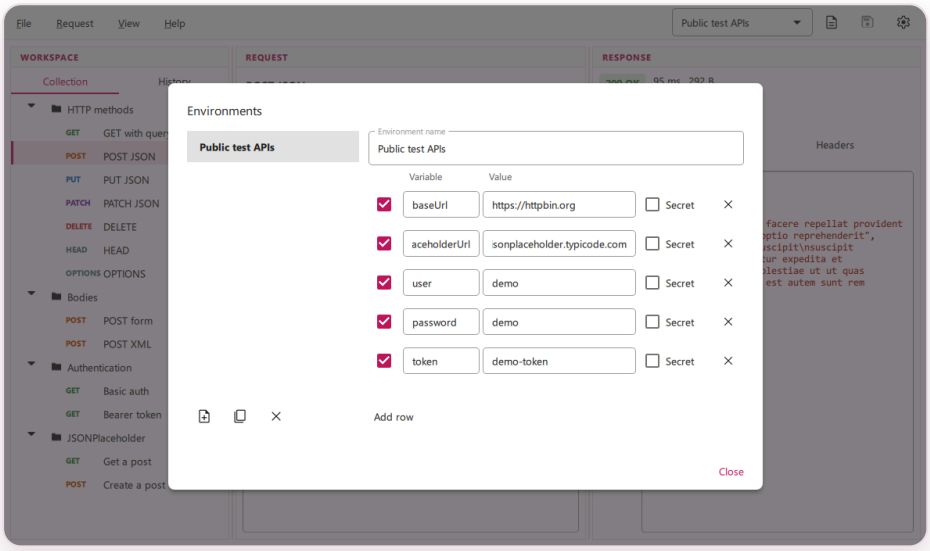
A JSON body for a POST request.

CHAPTER 3

Variables and environments

A variable is a name for a value you use in many requests. Write `{{baseUrl}}` instead of the full server address, and change the address in one place.

An environment is a set of variables. Make one for each server, for example Staging and Production, and switch between them at the top of the window.



Environments and their variables.

Tip

A `{{name}}` in red with an underline has no value in the active environment.

Careful

Tick Secret for passwords and keys. Their values are then kept out of the workspace file.

CHAPTER 4

Logging in: authentication

Many APIs answer only to users they know. The Auth tab adds the proof to each request.

Basic	User name and password.
Bearer	A token the service gave you.
API key	A key, sent as a header or a parameter.

> **Careful**
> Use variables such as `{{token}}` with Secret ticked, so the value is not saved in the workspace file.

CHAPTER 5

Reading the answer

The first number tells whether the request worked. Codes starting with 2 mean success, with 4 a problem with the request, with 5 a problem on the server.

200 OK	It worked.
201 Created	Something new was created.
204 No Content	It worked; there is nothing to show.
400 Bad Request	The server did not understand the request. Check the body and parameters.
401 Unauthorized	You are not logged in, or the token expired.
403 Forbidden	You are logged in but not allowed.
404 Not Found	Nothing at this address. Check the URL.
429 Too Many Requests	Slow down and try later.
500 Internal Server Error	The server failed. Not your fault, usually.



Status, time, size, and the body of the answer.

Tip

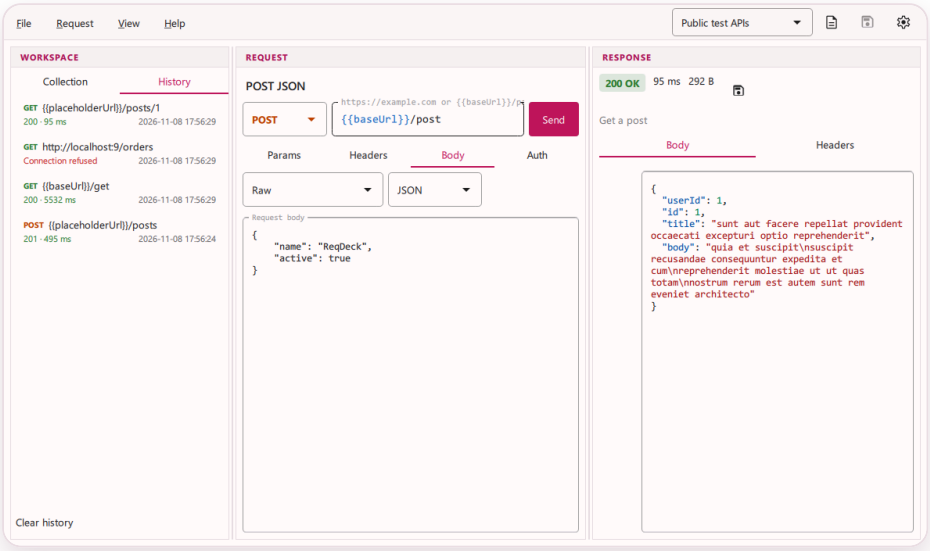
`Ctrl+F` finds text in the answer. The save button beside the size writes the answer to a file, also a very large one, of which only the start is shown.

CHAPTER 6

History and cURL

Every request you send lands in History, on the left. Double-click an entry to make a new request from it. Passwords and tokens written in a request are not kept there.

Documentation often shows requests as curl commands. Use File > Import cURL to turn one into a request, and Request > Copy as cURL to share yours.



History with the status of each request.

CHAPTER 7

When something does not work

Connection refused	Nothing answers at this address. Is the server running? Is the port right?
Host not found	The server name is wrong or the network is down.
Timeout	The server took too long. Raise the timeout or try later.
Unresolved variable	A `{{name}}` has no value. Pick the right environment.
Certificate error	The server's HTTPS certificate is not trusted, common on test servers. If you know the server, press Continue.
Proxy or company network	ReqDeck uses the proxy set in Windows, like your browser. Requests to your own computer always go directly.

Tip
View > Show Log Panel shows what ReqDeck did and what went wrong.

Keys worth knowing

`F1`	Explain what is under the pointer or in the field you type in.
`Ctrl` + `Enter`	Send the request.
`Ctrl` + `S`	Save the workspace.
`Ctrl` + `N`	Add a new request.
`Ctrl` + `O`	Open a workspace.
`Esc`	Close the help or a dialog.

Places to practice

https://httpbin.org
A free public API that answers whatever you send. Safe to experiment on.

https://developer.mozilla.org/docs/Web/HTTP/Status
Every HTTP status code explained.